



Figure 3: The new Menu added in GNOME 3



Figure 4: The Applications tab, displaying all the installed apps

will not interfere with the active application, but displays the message in a dialogue box that rises from the bottom of the display, and allows you to reply without minimising or closing the active app.

Unity vs GNOME 3

Unity, which was developed in a very short time, is preferred by most people for use on their laptops and net-books. GNOME 3 provides an interface suitable for both laptops and desktops. As GNOME 3 development started two years back, it ensures stability. Unity pushes the title bar and the menu bar of an application's window to the top panel, which provides more space to work on small screens (net-books). GNOME 3, too, ought to be able to detect the screen size of the system and introduce this feature in later versions.

Ubuntu's earlier versions included GNOME, making it the most preferred

desktop environment. However, starting with 11.04, Ubuntu replaced GNOME with Unity, which led to a decrease in GNOME's popularity. There is still a little hope for GNOME though, since Linux Mint, a distro based on Ubuntu, plans to ship Mint 11 with GNOME 3, without GNOME Shell.

Trying GNOME 3

The GNOME 3 preview can be tried in OpenSUSE 11.4. After installing OpenSUSE, you just have to update the system to try the GNOME 3 preview (or install GNOME Shell from the package manager). To try the actual GNOME 3 in OpenSUSE, you need to upgrade the OS to its Tumbleweed version, which is a rolling release of the OS, as follows:

```
zypper ar --refresh http://download.
opensuse.org/repositories/openSUSE:/
Tumbleweed/standard/ Tumbleweed
zypper dup --from Tumbleweed
```

Installing GNOME 3 in Ubuntu 10.10

In a terminal window, run the following code:

```
sudo add-apt-repository ppa:ricotz/testing
&& sudo apt-get update
sudo apt-get install gnome-shell
```

Next, hit Alt+F2, and run the command given below:

```
gnome-shell --replace
```

Installing GNOME 3 in Natty

In a terminal, run the following snippet of code:

```
sudo apt-add-repository ppa:gnome3-team/
gnome3
sudo apt-get update
sudo apt-get install gnome-desktop3
```

Other distros

I tried GNOME 3 in Debian, but the display crashed and I was left in a shell environment. For stability, Debian might not currently support GNOME 3 adequately. OpenSUSE 11.4 provides a GNOME 3 preview, but still has lots of glitches in the integration. Fedora 15 beta ships with GNOME 3, and gets the credit for the best integration of GNOME 3 with GNOME Shell.

Experiment with GNOME 3, and improve it. Spread the word on the use of GNOME 3-based distros to others. The questions at the beginning of the article can only be answered by those who have tried GNOME 3. Do check out the new GNOME 3 website, which has a lot more information on it, at: www.gnome.org/gnome-3. 

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